# When Wanting Turns Into Needing

Can I pursue this seriously without making a good life depend on getting it?

**READING**

**Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 2 and 4**. Desire and aversion promise getting or escaping something. At the baths, Epictetus's governing aim is to preserve sound choice. Preferred indifferents such as health and security deserve care; virtue determines whether we use them well.

**BEFORE THE MEETING**

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite members to notice a preference that feels like a requirement. A general example is enough.

| Open · 10 | Read · 10 | Discuss · 45 | Practice · 15 | Close · 10 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Optional January observation | Aloud, together | The questions below | Preference or requirement? | One takeaway each |

**DISCUSSION QUESTIONS**

1. What does something you want promise to give you — or protect you from?
2. How can you tell when a preference becomes something that must happen?
3. If the external goal stays the same, what changes when character governs the pursuit?
4. Can an unwanted outcome bring a real loss without making living well impossible?
5. Once the facts are settled, what would willingness to meet them mean without approving them?

**PRACTICE THIS MONTH**

**Prefer without requiring.** Choose one recurring want. Name its practical value, the condition you have attached to living well, and what stays worth wanting either way. When the demand returns, ask: **"Am I preferring this, or requiring it?"**

**FACILITATOR'S MOVE**

**"Necessary for what?"** Separate an actual practical need from a claim about the possibility of a good life. Allow disappointment and difficult answers.

**NOTES**